PAUL TONDEN, MBA

ENTERPRISE TRANSFORMATION & ORGANIZATIONAL EFFECTIVENESS

People Enablement | Workforce Transformation | Human-Centered AI Adoption

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PROFILE

Enterprise transformation and organizational effectiveness leader with seventeen years building the human systems that let complex, distributed organizations adapt, including a decade inside a publicly traded education technology and workforce solutions enterprise. The work spans digital transformation, merger integration, leadership and performance systems, organizational listening, global enablement, and capability building at scale. I get close to the people inside the problem, find the pattern, convene the right group, and design an intervention that leaves capability behind rather than dependence on me. Most of that has been accomplished through influence across executive and cross-functional stakeholders rather than positional authority. Current specialization: human-centered AI adoption, supported by executive consulting, applied AI-enabled operations, and doctoral research in strategy and innovation.

AREAS OF FOCUS

Enterprise Transformation • Organizational Effectiveness • M&A and Post-Merger Integration • Change Management • Leadership Architecture & Performance Systems • Employee Listening & Organizational Sensing • Learning and Capability Infrastructure • Executive Facilitation • Human-Centered AI Adoption • P&L Ownership

ENTERPRISE LEADERSHIP EXPERIENCE

Strategic Education, Inc. (SEI) 2020 – 2025

Senior Talent Development Consultant, Human Resources | Corporate | Herndon, VA (hybrid)

Publicly traded education technology and workforce solutions enterprise, approximately 9,000 employees globally. Portfolio has included Strayer University, Capella University, Sophia Learning, Workforce Edge, Jack Welch Management Institute, and Torrens University Australia. Reported to the VP of Talent; presented organizational findings to C-suite members monthly. Influence-based role across functions with no reporting line.

- Moved into the newly created corporate HR organization weeks before COVID sent a 70-plus campus workforce home. Led a team of three instructional designers to rebuild the enterprise learning ecosystem for roughly 3,000 distributed employees, converting campus-local physical knowledge into digital systems and deciding what belonged to the new corporate center versus each distinct business. Enabled approximately 300 leaders to train their own teams rather than routing demand through a small central function.
- Helped create, design, and deliver Elevate, SEI's first global enterprise leadership development program, reaching 300-plus people leaders across business units and countries. Established the company's first Leadership Community of Practice connecting roughly 700 US people leaders, built as a network of function-led communities with their own recruited leaders rather than a single central forum.
- Served as lead project manager and instructional designer for global annual compliance learning across roughly 9,000 employees, partnering with the CHRO and Chief Legal Officer to build an architecture that delivered common enterprise requirements alongside jurisdiction-, business-, and population-specific content as the company globalized. Introduced generative AI into the design process in the final iterations.
- Contributed to the design of SEI's organizational leadership behaviors and the Know Where You Stand performance process that laddered performance expectations to them. Helped develop and launch the Employee Voice survey and facilitated the leadership sensemaking that turned results into action.
- Selected to lead cross-institutional talent integration during the Capella and Strayer merger. Emceed the SEI Annual Summit executive leadership conference three consecutive years, 2023 to 2025. Elected co-chair of the CEO's Council on Diversity, Equity & Inclusion, a separately compensated leadership appointment.

Strayer University (Strategic Education, Inc.) 2015 – 2020

Washington, D.C. | Director-level leadership across a 70-plus campus national university system

Director, Academic Insights & Operations *2017 – 2020*

- Designed and led the Solutions Initiative, a three-year action-learning program in which three cohorts of academic leaders developed their capability by working real institutional problems named by the Chief Academic Officer. Interventions included an online cohorting model associated with year-over-year persistence and success gains and still in operation today, an honors program associated with improved completion, and cross-functional problem teams that became standard practice before the language was common. Many participants remain in institutional leadership.
- Owned the interface between the university and its academic partners across curriculum alignment, program development, and learning outcomes measurement.

Director, Campus Classroom Insights *2015 – 2017*

- Led a geographically distributed team of 20 to 30 Deans of Faculty spanning Texas through the Carolinas and Tennessee to New Jersey, developing them as coaches and local leaders and as the institution's most reliable source of ground-level organizational intelligence.
- Worked the strategic question of what physical presence should mean in an increasingly online model, traveling the campus network to gather qualitative and operational insight and participating in a Phoenix pilot testing whether geographically proximate online students benefit from community in the absence of a campus. The work informed institutional thinking on the campus footprint and the digital student experience.

Godiva Chocolatier / Gymboree Corporation 2009 – 2015

Multi-Unit, Multi-Brand District Manager | East Coast, Multi-State

- Ran a multi-brand retail district with full P&L accountability for sales, labor, inventory, merchandising, and staffing across geographically distributed teams. CEO Award, District of the Year, 2013, following double-digit year-over-year improvement across metrics.

INDEPENDENT PRACTICE AND ENTREPRENEURSHIP (2023 – PRESENT)

Paint It Black Design Group, LLC 2023 – Present

Principal | Human-Centered Systems Design and Leadership Development | Orlando, FL

- Designed and delivered a Human-Centered AI Leadership workshop for the executive leadership team and full corporate staff of Canon Financial Services, November 2025, covering responsible adoption culture, leadership self-assessment, and team dynamics, alongside Maxwell Leadership's The Leadership Game for the executive suite.

Praxis Studio, Inc. / Blue Moon Estate Sales Orlando West 2025 – Present

Founder & Operator | Ocoee, FL

- Founded and operate a franchise services business serving families through senior relocation, estate settlement, and downsizing, with full accountability for P&L, hiring, marketing, sales, and client experience; built the leadership team that now runs daily operations.
- Designed and run AI-enabled workflows for client settlement reporting, month-end reconciliation, cash-flow forecasting, and CRM, which double as applied research for the doctoral work.

EXECUTIVE FACILITATION & SPEAKING

Emcee, SEI Annual Summit Executive Leadership Conference, 2023 to 2025, with decision rights over facilitation, flow, tone, and attendee experience. Emcee, Strayer Academic Leadership Conference, three years. Designed and delivered Designing Your Life, a five-week course for SEI employees and affiliates, quarterly. Design Thinking for Leadership workshops at institutional leadership conferences. Commencement committees and name reader for Strayer University, Capella University, and the Jack Welch Management Institute.

Co-host and co-producer, Thought Partners podcast. Adjunct instructor: Post University, First-Year Experience, current; Rowan University, Department of Speech & Theatre, 1996 to 2003.

EDUCATION & CREDENTIALS

DBA, Strategy & Innovation, Capella University (expected 2027). Dissertation in progress: how mid- to senior-level leaders understand and enact human-centered values when integrating generative AI to support employee creativity, learning, and well-being.

MBA, Jack Welch Management Institute, 2018 | BA, Speech & Theatre, Rowan University

Maxwell Leadership Certified Coach, Speaker & Trainer • HBDI Certified Practitioner, 500-plus individual and team debriefs • Everything DiSC Certified Facilitator • LeadX Emotional Intelligence Certification